

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 11 — “What Walks the Wastes”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom.

Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screentone ash.

Approx. 28 pages.

PAGE 1

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (wide, full-width top — dawn (the Wastes’ gray version))

The camp wakes to SILENCE. Too much silence. The usual sounds — whispers, footsteps, the crackle of cold fire — are gone.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow, center)

BORCHU stands at the watch post, frozen, staring outward. His broken weapon hangs loose in his hand.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

Close on his face — pale, eyes wide.

No dialogue.

PAGE 2

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS approaches from behind.

EGRIS: “Borchu.”

Panel 2

BORCHU does not turn. Does not answer.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS stops beside him and looks out at what he’s seeing.

No dialogue.

Panel 4 (narrow, what they see)

The horizon. Empty. But WRONG. The mist has pulled back — revealing the Wastes for miles in every direction. And moving through it, toward the camp: A SHAPE.

No dialogue.

PAGE 3

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — page-turn reveal)

IT walks on two legs, but is NOT human. Enormous — twenty feet tall, made of ASH and BONE and RUIN pressed into the vague shape of a man. Its head is a broken helm from some forgotten war. Its arms are pillars of calcified stone and rusted weapons fused together. Where its heart should be: a VOID, a hole that pulls light into it.

It walks slowly. Deliberately. Each step SHAKES the ground.

SFX: BOOM... BOOM... BOOM...

PAGE 4

Panels: 3

Panel 1

BORCHU, barely a whisper.

BORCHU: "What is that?"

Panel 2

EGRIS, eyes never leaving the thing.

EGRIS: "The Wastes."

Panel 3

BORCHU: "What?"

PAGE 5

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS: "It is made from the Wastes. Ash. Bone. The ruins themselves."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Someone sent it. Gave it shape. Gave it purpose."

Panel 3

BORCHU: "To do what?"

Panel 4

The THING takes another step closer. The ground cracks beneath it.

SFX: BOOM

PAGE 6

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS: "To finish what the Echo warriors could not."

Panel 2

SURO appears beside them, sword already drawn.

SURO: "It is coming for you."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "For all of us."

PAGE 7**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

SURO tilts his blindfolded head, listening.

SURO: "No. Only you. The rest of us are just in its way."

Panel 2

BORCHU: "Then we run. Move the camp—"

Panel 3

EGRIS, cutting him off.

EGRIS: "It will follow. It will not stop until it has what it came for."

Panel 4

BORCHU: "Then what do we do?"

PAGE 8**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top)

EGRIS turns to face the camp. Forty-three souls, most awake now, staring at the approaching colossus. Terror in every face.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

EGRIS: "We stand."

PAGE 9**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

The WOMAN IN RED steps forward, the boy still clinging to her.

WOMAN: "Stand? Against that?"

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Yes."

Panel 3

WOMAN: "We will die."

Panel 4

EGRIS: “We are already dead. The question is whether we die kneeling or standing.”

PAGE 10**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The camp STIRS. Murmurs. Fear. But also something else — a memory of what it felt like to choose. No dialogue.

Panel 2

BORCHU, grim but resolute, grips his weapon tighter.

BORCHU: “Where do you want us?”

Panel 3

EGRIS: “I do not want you anywhere. You choose where you stand.”

PAGE 11**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

BORCHU stares at him.

BORCHU: “Egris, this is not the time for philosophy—”

Panel 2

EGRIS, hard.

EGRIS: “This is the ONLY time for it. If I command you, I become what they want me to be. If you follow orders, you become what they want you to be.”

Panel 3

EGRIS: “Choose, Borchu. All of you. Choose.”

PAGE 12**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top — the camp decides)

For a long moment, no one moves. Then BORCHU steps forward, positioning himself beside Egris. Then the WOMAN IN RED — she releases the boy’s hand and picks up a broken length of stone. Then AR-GHUN, clutching his satchel but standing. Then the young SOLDIER from Chapter 5. Then another soul. And another. No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

Not all of them. Ten souls remain behind — the boy, a few too injured to fight, others simply too afraid. But THIRTY-THREE stand. Not because Egris commanded it. Because they chose. No dialogue.

PAGE 13

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — the line forms)

The thirty-three souls form a ragged LINE across the camp's edge. No formation. No discipline. Just people standing together because they decided to. EGRIS at the center, SURO to his left, BORCHU to his right. The COLOSSUS still approaching, now only a hundred paces away.

SFX: BOOM... BOOM... BOOM...

PAGE 14

Panels: 4

Panel 1

SURO, calm.

SURO: "You cannot kill it. It is made of the Wastes themselves. Strike it and it reforms."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Then we do not kill it. We stop it."

Panel 3

SURO: "How?"

Panel 4

EGRIS: "The same way I stopped the Echo warriors. We refuse it."

PAGE 15

Panels: 3

Panel 1

BORCHU: "That thing does not care about refusal—"

Panel 2

EGRIS: "No. But whoever sent it does."

Panel 3

The COLOSSUS is fifty paces away now. Its void-heart PULLS at the air, at the light, at the souls themselves.

SFX (deep, hollow): hhhhhhhh...

PAGE 16

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top — it STOPS)

The colossus halts, thirty paces from the line. Its broken-helm head tilts down, regarding the standing souls.

SFX: ...

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

Silence. The ground stops shaking. The void-heart continues to pull, but the thing does NOT advance.
No dialogue.

PAGE 17**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

The WOMAN whispers.

WOMAN: "Why did it stop?"

Panel 2

SURO, quiet realization.

SURO: "Because we are standing in its way."

Panel 3

SURO: "And it was not given permission to harm us. Only Egris."

Panel 4

EGRIS: "Then it has a choice. Go through them to reach me. Or leave."

PAGE 18**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The COLOSSUS does not move.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Then, from deep within its void-heart, a VOICE — not its own, but the one who sent it. The FORMER RIVAL's voice, distorted and distant.

RIVAL'S VOICE: "Step aside. This does not concern you."

Panel 3

The standing souls DO NOT MOVE.

No dialogue.

PAGE 19**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

RIVAL'S VOICE: "You follow a man who will lead you to ruin. Step aside and you will be spared."

Panel 2

BORCHU, loud enough for the voice to hear.

BORCHU: "We do not follow him."

Panel 3

RIVAL'S VOICE: "Then why do you stand with him?"

Panel 4

The WOMAN IN RED, gripping her broken stone.

WOMAN: "Because we choose to."

PAGE 20**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top — the void-heart FLARES)

The colossus TREMBLES. The void-heart burns brighter, pulling harder. The souls in the line feel it — a cold dragging at their chests, trying to pull them forward, trying to make them MOVE.

SFX: HHHHHHHHHH

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

They HOLD. Feet planted. Weapons raised. Terrified. But standing.

No dialogue.

PAGE 21**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

RIVAL'S VOICE, colder now.

RIVAL'S VOICE: "So be it."

Panel 2

The colossus raises one massive arm — the one made of fused weapons and stone. It is going to strike. Not Egris. The LINE.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS steps FORWARD, separating himself from the others.

EGRIS: "Stop."

PAGE 22**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

The colossus PAUSES, arm raised.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

EGRIS: "You came for me. Take me. Leave them."

Panel 3

BORCHU: "Egris—"

Panel 4

EGRIS, not looking back.

EGRIS: "This is my choice."

PAGE 23**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top)

The colossus lowers its arm. Then it reaches for EGRIS with one enormous hand—

Panel 2 (wide, bottom — SURO MOVES)

SURO is FASTER. He crosses the distance in a single motion, sword flashing, and CUTS through the colossus's wrist. The hand separates, dissolving into ash before it hits the ground.

SFX: SHNNNG—fwsss

PAGE 24**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The colossus RECOILS, stumbling backward. The wrist reforms — ash and bone knitting together — but SURO has already moved.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

SURO, calm, sword ready.

SURO: "You said we choose, Egris. I choose to stand here."

Panel 3

BORCHU and the WOMAN step forward, joining Suro.

BORCHU: "So do I."

WOMAN: "And I."

PAGE 25**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top)

One by one, the thirty-three souls ADVANCE — not running, not charging. WALKING. Slow. Deliberate. Together.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

The colossus STEPS BACK. For the first time, it retreats.

SFX: BOOM

PAGE 26

Panels: 3

Panel 1

RIVAL'S VOICE, from the void-heart, disbelieving.

RIVAL'S VOICE: "You would die for a man who will not lead you?"

Panel 2

EGRIS, walking with the others now.

EGRIS: "They are not dying for me. They are choosing their own path."

Panel 3

RIVAL'S VOICE: "There is no difference—"

PAGE 27

Panels: 2

Panel 1

EGRIS: "There is every difference. And that is why you will never understand."

Panel 2 (wide, bottom — the colossus COLLAPSES)

The void-heart FLICKERS. The colossus's form BREAKS APART, ash and bone and ruin scattering across the ground. Whatever force held it together — the Rival's will, his certainty — has been broken by something he cannot accept: people choosing to stand without being commanded.

SFX: KRRRSSHHH

PAGE 28

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — closing image)

The colossus is gone. Only a field of scattered ash and broken stone remains. The thirty-three souls stand in the silence, weapons still raised, breathing hard. EGRIS at the center, SURO beside him. The camp safe. For now.

In the distance, barely visible, a FIGURE watches from the horizon — the FORMER RIVAL, standing alone. He turns and walks away.

NARRATION (box, lower corner): He had sent a monster to destroy what he could not control. And they had defeated it by refusing to be controlled themselves.

— END OF CHAPTER 11 —

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left. Panel 1 sits at top-right of every page.
- **The colossus design:** 20 feet tall, made of ash/bone/ruins, broken helm for a head, void-heart in the chest, arms of fused weapons and stone. It should feel like the Wastes given terrible purpose — not demonic, not holy, just WRONG.

- **Page 13 splash (the line forms)** — show the visual contrast between this ragged line and the perfect Echo warrior formation from Ch.9. These people are NOT soldiers. They are individuals choosing to stand together.
- **Page 23 (Suro's cut)** — the ONLY action beat in the chapter. Make it fast, clean, decisive. Suro is not fighting the colossus — he is making a statement.
- **Page 27 (the colossus collapses)** — it does NOT die in battle. It falls apart because the Rival's will sustaining it has been broken by witnessing something he cannot understand. Show it crumbling, not exploding.
- **The Former Rival (final panel)** — just a silhouette on the horizon. He is still alive, still out there, but he has learned something that troubles him.
- **Tone:** This is the action climax, but it is WON through philosophy, not violence. The souls choose to stand, and that choice is the weapon.